

Anilius scytale

South American pipe snake



Length 28–35 in (70–90 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



The sole member of the family Aniliidae, this little-known snake leads a secretive, underground life, its cylindrical body shape adapted to its burrowing habit. The striking red and black coloration



mimics that of venomous coral snakes from the same region, whose defensive behavior the South American pipe snake also imitates. It hunts in burrows, and its diet is thought to consist of small vertebrates, including snakes. It may be preyed upon by other snakes.

Cylindrophis ruffus

Red-tailed pipe snake



Length 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia

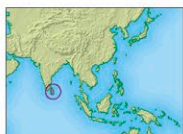


The underside of this slender snake's tail is red, hence its name. The upper body is black, often with a red mark behind the head. Living mainly underground, this pipe snake

occasionally takes to water and may be found in rice paddies and swamps. It actively forages for smaller snakes and eels. Hunted by larger snakes, birds, and mammals, its defense is to raise its tail and expose the red underside, possibly to mimic venomous species such as the krait, or to deflect attack away from its head.

*Pseudotyphlops philippinus*

Large shield-tailed snake



Length 18–20 in (45–50 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

Location Sri Lanka, below 3,300 ft (1,000 m)



This short, stout, mainly brown snake, with yellow edges to its scales, has a tail that ends with a single shield or caudal plate and looks as though it has been chopped off at an oblique angle. The shield, covered with tiny spines that are more concentrated around the edge, is believed to plug the burrow down which the snake moves, keeping it safe from predators. Rarely coming to the surface, the snake has the cylindrical body, pointed head, and smooth scales of a burrowing species, and feeds on the earthworms it finds underground. As with other members of the family Uropeltidae, little is known about this species' social, defensive, or reproductive behavior.

Loxocemus bicolor

Mexican burrowing snake



Length 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location S. Mexico to Central America



This constrictor has the narrow head and cylindrical, muscular body of a burrowing species. Its body is gray, with irregular patches of white scales that develop with age. This snake eats rodents, lizards, and reptile eggs, and is hunted by birds and mammals. Females lay 3–6 large, thick-shelled eggs in chambers dug in soil or leaf litter.

*Xenopeltis unicolor*

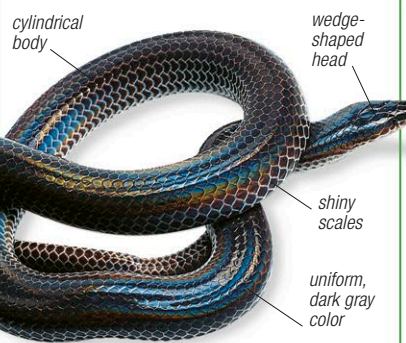
Sunbeam snake



Location S.E. Asia



Length 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern



Named after its highly polished, iridescent scales, this snake has the typical body adaptations of a burrowing species. It comes above ground only at night, and eats frogs, lizards, snakes, and small mammals. Females lay 6–9 eggs in underground nests in soil or leaf litter. The young have a distinct white collar that disappears after 2–3 molts.

Casarea dussumieri

Round Island boa

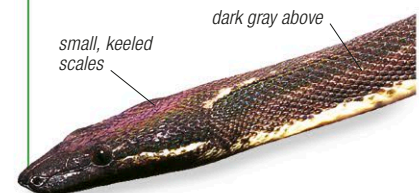


Location Round Island, in Indian Ocean



Length 3¼–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Endangered

Poorly known and seldom seen, the Round Island boa is one of the world's most rare snakes, with perhaps only about 1,000 left in the wild. It feeds on lizards, and its narrow head and slender body allow it to squeeze between rocks, so that it can creep up on its prey. Unlike true boas, which bear live young, this species lays eggs, in crevices where leaf litter has accumulated. A breeding program is currently underway to save this snake, but its closest relative, *Bolyeria multicarinata*—also from Round Island—has not been seen since 1975, and is probably extinct.

*Acrantophis dumerili*

Dumeril's boa



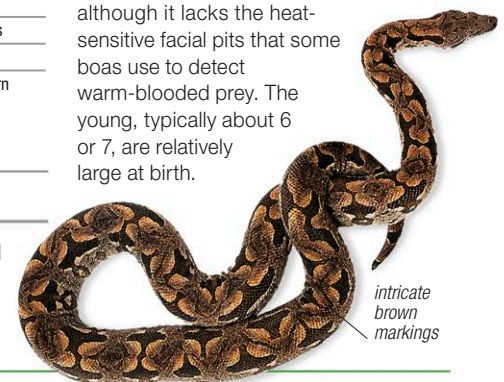
Location S. and W. Madagascar



Length 5–6½ ft (1.5–2 m)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Dumeril's boa is intricately patterned in shades of brown, with distinctive, glossy black markings around the mouth. A fairly inactive snake, it

prefers to stay hidden in leaf litter on the floor of dry forest, its coloration allowing it to blend in almost imperceptibly. This boa ambushes and constricts its prey, which includes mammals and birds—although it lacks the heat-sensitive facial pits that some boas use to detect warm-blooded prey. The young, typically about 6 or 7, are relatively large at birth.

*Calabaria reinhardtii*

Calabar ground boa



Location W. and C. Africa



Length 3–3½ ft (0.9–1.1 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

This boa has a blunt head and a tail that are hard to tell apart. When threatened, it coils into a ball and raises its tail as a "false head" to protect its real head. The scales are black or brown, scattered with red or orange. The Calabar ground boa

hunts small mammals in their tunnels and nests, and rarely comes above ground. Formerly classified as a python, it is now considered to be the only egg-laying species of boa.

